



Illustration Shyam Shriram

Your Café On The Web

Social networking online can help your business grow

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Then: BBS, Usenet, IRC, Yahoo! Groups, IMs

Now: Orkut, Ryze, Wallop, Bebo, Friendster, Yahoo! 360°, Tribe, Hi5

When blogs first hit the Internet a few years ago, almost everyone viewed them with suspicion and disdain: “Online diaries? Who cares?”

A lot has changed since. Blogs have made news—both good and bad. While blog-writing is still a long way from being considered mainstream journalism, some bloggers have managed to bag lucrative book deals from publishing houses. Several online organisations have even instituted annual awards for the best blogs in categories ranging from striking design to thought-provoking content.

Blogs have also helped people across the world connect, almost instantly, with people they share interests with. By leaving notes or comments on each other's blogs, and being part of blog-rings, people can now form micro-communities on the Web.

This isn't very different in principle from Internet message boards, or even Yahoo! Groups, blog-rings help personalise the community—one can know more about the person he or she is communicating with, the simple reason being that the writer's thoughts and expressions are recorded on his or her blog.

By Invitation Only

Then, Gmail happened. Gmail used the most potent marketing gimmick ever—exclusivity—to launch its much-hyped 1 GB mail account. Gmail accounts, offered on a trial basis to select bloggers, pushed the ego button: they were available ‘by invitation only’, causing an online stampede to secure invites—even spawning sites such as gmailswap.com, where people made ludicrous offers in exchange for Gmail invites.

Along with Gmail, Google launched their social networking venture, Orkut (www.orkut.com). Securing membership to Orkut was, again, ‘by invitation only’. Orkut shared space with other communities such as Friendster (www.friendster.com), and business networking site Ryze (www.ryze.com), which also organises regular, paid offline events. These